Kurmi leader and Union MoS for finance, Pankaj Chaudhary, a six-time party MP from Maharajganj, on July 7 during a visit to Gorakhpur. It is rare for the PM to take such a detour, and the story goes that it was the ruling BJP's nod to show how important the community was for them.

It seems like everyone is out to corner the Kurmi vote. On July 18, at the meeting of the Opposition's INDIA alliance in Bengaluru, everyone noted the presence of Krishna Patel, president of the Apna Dal (K) faction. She and her daughter Pallavi, the MLA from Sitharu, are in a tussle with her other daughter Anupriya Patel—Union minister and head of the Apna Dal(S)—over the legacy of her husband, the late Sonelal Patel, among the first to champion the idea of Kurmis as a voting bloc.

Apna Dal (S) chief Anupriya Patel is at odds with the family over the legacy of Kurmi titan Sonelal Patel



ANI

In the 2022 assembly election, 41 Kurmi candidates won—27 from the BJP alliance, 13 from the SP and one from the Congress. Political analyst Shilp Shikha Singh says, "In UP, the Yadavs have dominated in the past, but there have been several tall Kurmi leaders like Sonelal Patel, Beni Prasad Verma and Ram Pujan Patel. But the Kurmis never aligned with a single party. What the parties are doing now is trying to consolidate the community vote. The war between the Patel sisters (Anupriya and Pallavi) and the speculation over Nitish have only added to the spice in Kurmi politics. Every party is wooing them."

From Rohilkhand in northwestern UP to Sonbhadra in the east, the Kurmis cut a wide swathe. The community makes up almost 20 per cent of the population in some seats (*see map*) and, according to data from the past few elections, tend to vote en bloc to further their interests. As for the big Kurmi leaders in UP, in the Bareilly-Pilibhit belt, they don't come any bigger than the BJP's Santosh Gangwar, an eight-term MP from Bareilly. In the Kheri-Sitapur belt, Ravi Verma, Rakesh Verma and Rekha Verma are the big guns. The SP's Ravi is a former four-term MP; his daughter Purvi Verma now lays claim to his legacy. Rekha is a two-term BJP MP from the Dhaurahra seat and a member of the party's national executive. As for Rajesh Verma, he is a four- term BJP MP from Sitapur. In the Barabanki-Gonda region, the family of the late SP leader Beni Prasad Verma still has influence. In Ambedkar Nagar, the SP relies on its heavyweight Lalji Verma and in Awadh and Purvanchal, the Apna Dal factions are fighting for dominance.

Even the state organisations of parties now have heavy Kurmi presence. The BJP state president till late, Swatantra Dev Singh, was a Kurmi. The SP has seven Kurmis in its state committee, including state president Naresh Uttam Patel. So how will the moves for Kurmi consolidation pan out? It's too early to say, though if Nitish does throw his hat in the ring, it could set off a wave. ■



By Rahul Noronha

In poll-bound Madhya Pradesh, godmen and politicians are natural allies. Several prominent leaders from both the BJP and Congress are deploying babas of various hues to rally the faithful to their electoral cause.

Never before has the intertwining of religion and politics been so pronounced in the run-up to an election in MP. Hindu religious preachers—ranging from the well-known to the emerging—are crisscrossing the state, delivering professionally organised sermons at the behest of their political hosts. The magnetic pull of their sermons endears crowds numbering in the hundreds of thousands and makes them a coveted asset for politicians seeking an edge in the assembly election scheduled for November.

Interestingly, the utilisation of these preachers isn't exclusive to leaders of the BJP, often accused of practising Hindu nationalism. These godmen are being used as much by members of the Congress, who adopt 'soft Hindutva' to counter their opponents.

Foremost among these babas is the enigmatic Dhirendra Krishna Shastri of Bageshwar Dham in Chhatarpur. Shastri hit the headlines when a rationalist organisation in Nagpur challenged his claimed miracles. Practically every politician aspiring to contest the election is vying for his favour, except perhaps